



FIFA Elections -
Staining the
Beautiful Game

OP-ED by LAWRENCE
PANG

Most serious perhaps was his decision to hand the 2022 World Cup to Qatar, where it is projected that thousands of migrant workers will die building FIFA's stadiums. Despite the fact that Qatar's summers (which can reach 40 degrees Celsius) are far too warm for soccer, and hosting the Cup in winter would mess up club soccer schedules across the world, FIFA has inexplicably awarded Qatar the world's most-watched sporting tournament. Inexplicably, that is, if you discount the ever-present allegations that Qatar bribed Blatter for the World Cup.

See FIFA on P3

TDSB
Supplies

OP-ED by DAVID CHEN-
LI

High schools in the Toronto District School Board offer students a wide variety of subjects and courses to choose from apart from the fundamental courses. From robotics, computer engineering, and tech design to photography, visual arts, and music, these elective courses provide students with an opportunity to pursue a field of interest and study it. To top it off, the TDSB provides supplies and budgeting for these courses as well. However, the TDSB system for distributing supplies for school departments limits the flexibility and potential for growth of elective departments.

See TDSB Supplies on P3

From Butch-
ering Pigs to
Butchering
Egos

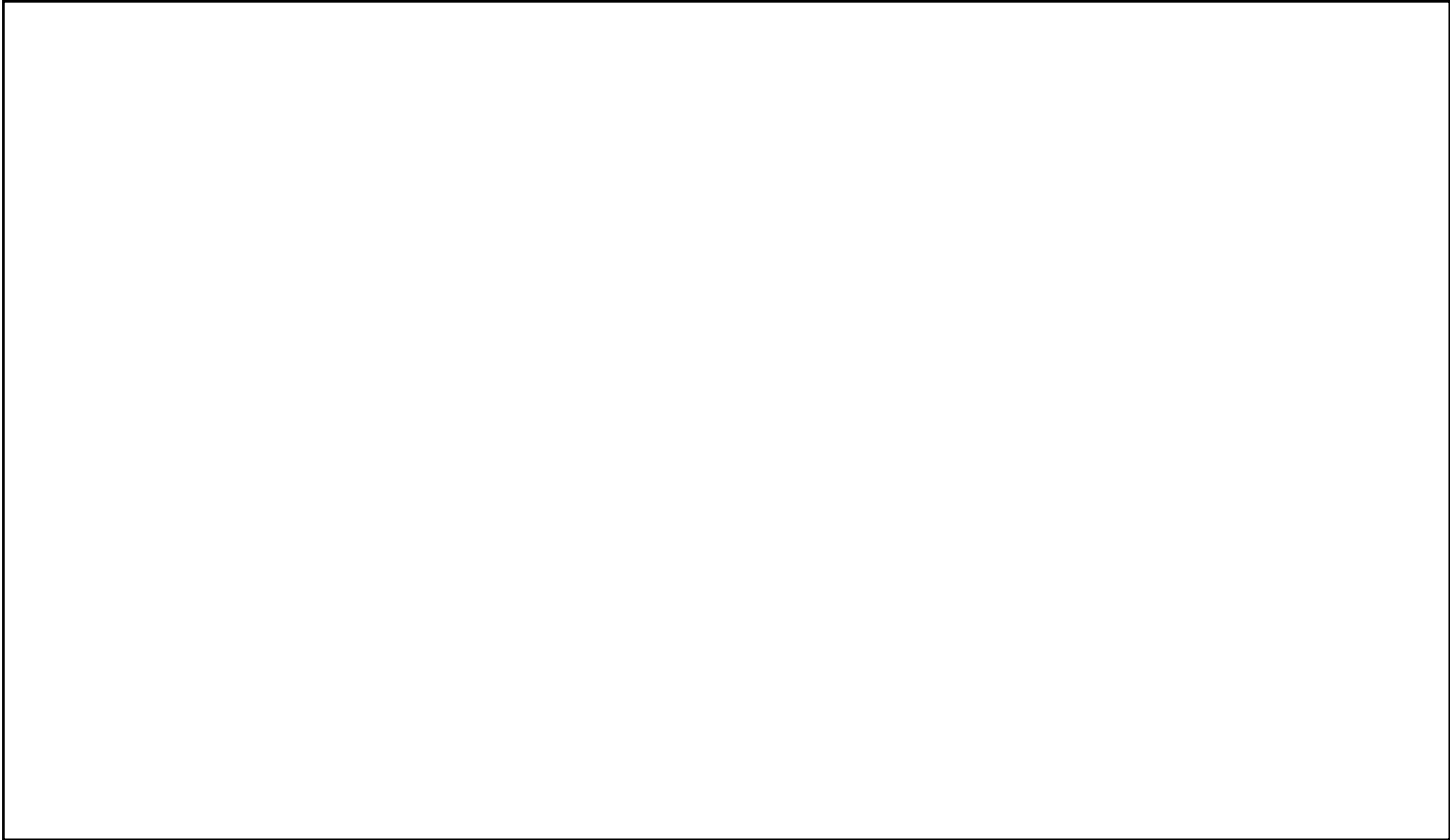
by DAVID HAO and
CINDY ZENG

Q: What advice would you give to the average Garneau student?
A: Get emotionally involved with your studies and work as hard at whatever interesting subjects you have, that play into you, as hard as you can, and build the best possible life for yourselves.
Q: How long have you been working at MGCI?
A: This is my 18th year.
Q: What courses do you teach at Garneau?
A: Right now? Over the years I've taught a lot of math, as well as general science. But for the last while I've primarily been teaching the AP physics course, the Astronomy course, the grade 11 TOPS physics and the gr 10 science – that's been primarily my undertaking.
Q: How did you jump from the meat business to physics, and why physics?
A: I always had an interest in astronomy and things like that, over the years as a boy, even quite involved, when I was 6 or 7 years old. And so this always maintained itself throughout my time, and when I was in my own business I didn't have time for that. But in the late 80s, the regulations changed and it was going to make it quite expensive to operate given what you make on the deal.

See van Bommel on P4

Robots Get Real

Garneau's new robotics team took it to the top at the Toronto Regional Competition of Educational Robotics this weekend. With just two weeks to build three robots, the young team amazed by placing first overall.



Caption Caption
Photo courtesy of Saiyam Patel

by REBECCA WONG

On 18 April 2015, four representatives from the MGCI Robotics team competed in the Toronto Regional Competition of Educational Robotics at the Toronto Ouest High School. MGCI Robotics President Saiyam Patel and team members John Le, James Robins, and Akef Ahmed attended the competition, where they placed first and won four medals, the maximum number a team could win. The MGCI Robotics Club, which has about 15 members, found out about the competition two weeks prior to the event. They built and programmed three robots from scratch for each of the three challenges, using the equipment that previously belonged to last year's robotics club. Due to the tight time constraint, in addition to working on the robots at school, some members brought the robots home in order to finish building them. The three challenges that the team built robots for were the New Horizons, Dangerous Satellite, and Space Walk challenges. The team won first place for their New Horizons robot, which was

suspended by a string and rotated to locate and identify surrounding objects. As the most difficult robot to program and design, it simulated NASA's New Horizons space probe which was sent to study the outer limits of the solar system. The Dangerous Satellite challenge, which was of a medium difficulty, required students to build robots that could protect themselves from a "defective satellite", another robot, by forcing them into another orbit to avoid collisions. This sumo-bot challenge had robots try to force their opponents out of the playing field without going off themselves. MGCI placed second in this challenge. MGCI came in third place in the Space Walk challenge, which was the easiest of the three. The robot was built and programmed to move back and forth along a rail. It had to detect different objects along the rail, and then remove them and dispose of them by placing them in a specially marked area. This challenge simulated the removal of debris lodged in the space station in order to be able to repair damage.

The fourth medal that the team won was a special honour award for building robots for all three challenges in only two weeks. Although the team placed first, this year the Toronto regional competition was not connected to the national competition, so MGCI will not be moving on past the regional competition. Club president Saiyam Patel described the competition as "very upbeat and competitive" because of the challenges such as the "robot sumo battle which really set the mood, pushing you to do your best." At the competition, MGCI was one of the only teams to use outdated equipment, making challenges more difficult for the members. The club has recently purchased the most up-to-date robotics equipment, worth over one thousand dollars, using money from sponsorships obtained for the competition. The club members will now be learning how to use this new equipment in preparation for their next competition, the UOIT Robotics Competition, which will take place in the next school year.

What's up, SAC?

by BOSHEN CUI

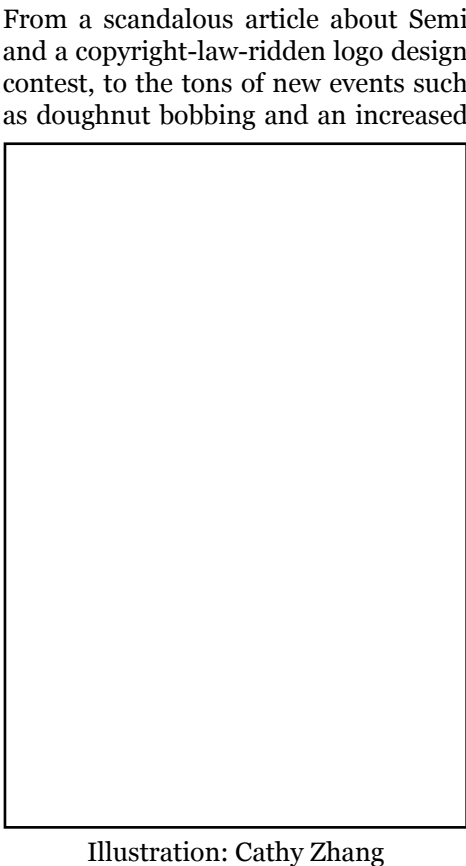


Illustration: Cathy Zhang

From a scandalous article about Semi and a copyright-law-ridden logo design contest, to the tons of new events such as doughnut bobbing and an increased student presence, MGCI's student activity council's (SAC) work has been nothing short of a hell of a ride this year. Recently, SAC put up a poster summarizing their achievements and future plans in the gallery. President Maria Kashif explained that often, students didn't know and understand the role of SAC, or what they typically accomplish. She stated that the infographic was created to inform students and answer questions. In the remaining two months of the school year, SAC aims to complete an ambitious amount of projects. These include everything from planning Spring Fling, Athletic Banquet, Grad Tea, Prom, and a special end of the year event, to releasing club budgets to the public, updating the SAC constitution, and creating a website. President Kashif remains optimistic that this will all be done in the given time frame, "I know it's a lot of things to pull off in the short time we have left but we have specific members responsible for specific tasks and I really believe in all the members

on our SAC." Many students felt satisfied with SAC's progress. Bapisha Balakumar, a grade 11 student, commented, "It's nice to actually know that SAC is doing all these things for campaigns and for the school. [T]hey actually do stuff this year." When asked about what SAC's priorities should be, many students overwhelmingly agreed that organizing school-wide events took precedence over administrative work. President Kashif said that she's felt that SAC had improved from year to year, recalling dark times when sweaters were \$45, and the only planned events were Semi and Prom. She believes that "students are starting to acknowledge that SAC is a large contributor to a lot of the events and activities that happen at Garneau... and so I believe the student body generally views SAC positively," while there are "tons of people that probably don't care," SAC will continue to work its hardest.

Teacher Feature: Mr. Alexander

by DEIFILIA TO



Mr. Alexander
Photo: Deifilia To

Q: *What is a favourite quote that you have?*
A: Take your heart to work everyday, and expect the best and most out of everybody else too. By Meryl Streep.
Q: *What's your favourite time of the day?*
A: When I'm teaching.
Q: *Are there any specific things that you like about it? Or do you just like it in general?*
A: It's just the interaction, and watching things fall in place for my students.
Q: *Who's a role model that you have?*
A: My parents.
Q: *Has it always been that way since you were young?*
A: Yes. It's always been that way
Q: *If you could have any animal as a pet, what would it be?*
A: I've had deer, my family's been involved in the raising of an elephant, I've had duck, I've had rabbits, I've had dogs, cats, all of that stuff. I'll go with giraffe. So long as somebody else pays the cost.
Q: *If you could have any superpower, what would it be?*
A: I don't think I need anymore. I think I have all the ones I need.
Q: *What is one song that can summarize your life or your values?*
A: There is one song that I find is quite resonant. It doesn't necessarily represent everything about my life, but every time I hear it, it makes me feel special. It's the one we used on the Grade 12 exam last year. I hope you dance.
Q: *Who's it by?*
A: Lee Ann Womack
Q: *Try to summarize the meaning of life to you in six words or less.*
A: Give and let give.
Q: *Are you an introvert or an extrovert?*
A: I'm kind of both. Happily in the middle.
Q: *Why do you teach?*
A: I didn't want to be a teacher. When I was young, I wanted to be a doctor. Then I ended up becoming a journalist, and then I also became a teacher at the time due to circumstances in my family. I don't know there is any other profession where you get to go in every day to a group of 30-35 of the brightest minds 3 times a day. Every class is an opportunity to go into a room of 30-35 bright minds that vary from ready to tear you down, to ready to absorb everything you have to make available to them, and that I find is quite exciting.
Q: *So would you say it's due to the variety you get out of teaching?*
A: No, it's the fact that if you know what you're doing and you do it well, they fully engage. It's a really rewarding experience to have that many people trust you and then actually discover that their trust was worth it.

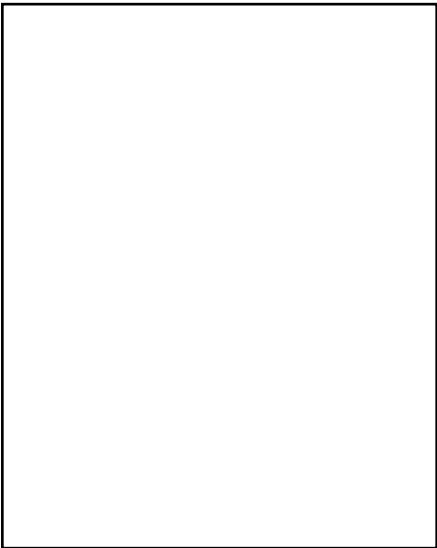
See ALEXANDER on P3



LIFE

Pillow Fight Toronto 2015

by BILL XUN



Torontonians gathered in Nathan Phillips Square for a massive pillow fight. Photo courtesy of Vanessa Du

Carry a pillow while strolling down Yonge Street any day of the year and people will look at you funny. They'll probably think you're insecure, and a little crazy too. But on one day every year – International Pillow Fight Day – it's the exact opposite.

On 4 April 2015, dozens of cities from across the world participated in this fluffy flash mob, and Toronto was no exception. Nathan Phillips Square was at the center of it all. With excitement in the air, it seemed as though the entire downtown core was much

more welcoming than usual. There were pillows on the subway, on the street, in restaurants. And something about people with pillows downtown brought a smile to everyone's face, pillow or not. The fight began at 3 pm as hundreds of people let loose on each other and an equal amount of curious bystanders came to see what all the commotion was about. The rules were simple: bring a soft pillow, and avoid hitting camer-

as. The combatants quickly converged into a swarm of pillows and people in the middle of the square, with loud music blasting into the circle. The swarm of people grew and grew, and soon rivaled the swarm of late students outside the Galleria in the morning.

For the first 30 minutes, the pillow assault was endless. The only sound louder than the music was the screams of laughter. Charging into the center, with your pillow swinging, everyone was your target. Some people played whack-a-mole. Others held their pillows out and spun like a top. As you pushed through to the center, you saw all kinds of people – Adults, teens, children, university students, people in banana suits, bunny suits, penguin suits. Interspersed between this diverse crowd

were photographers who jumped in for the perfect shot, and left with shots to the head.

As the fight progressed, it became much more organized. People began to gang up on each other.

"Get the banana!" someone would scream. "Get the penguin!"

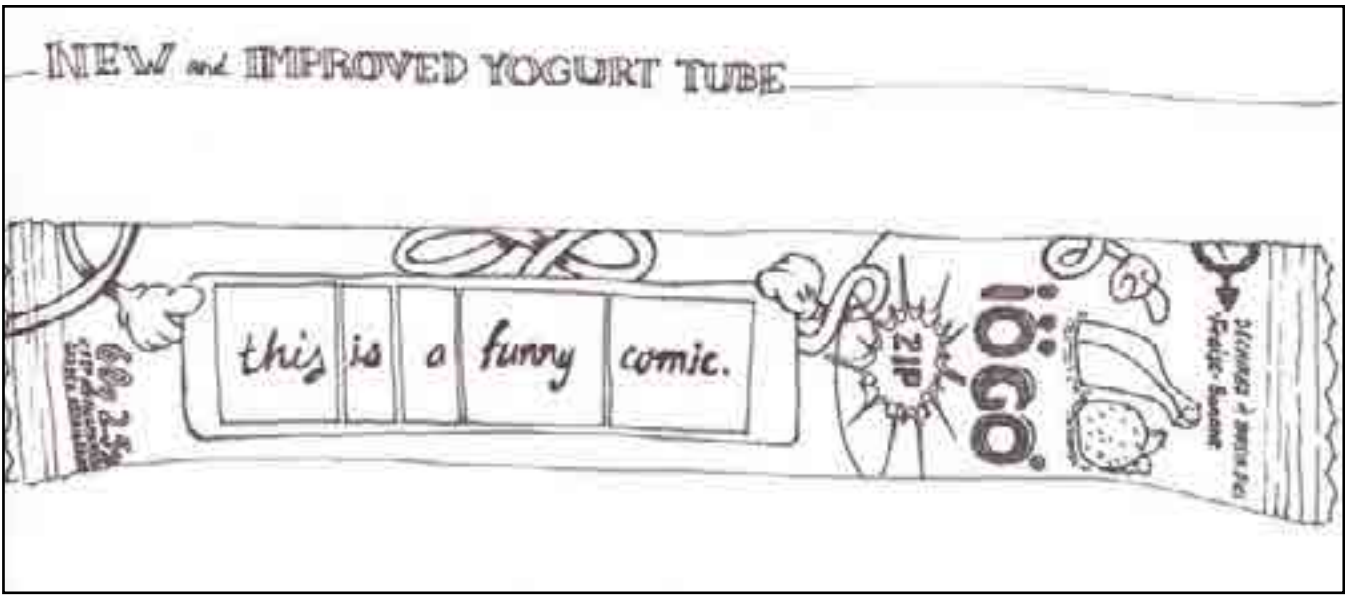
These people would immediately be beaten to the ground by a circle of pillows, then helped up. Small skirmishes began to break out on the side. Once you made eye contact with someone, you were obligated to duel it out, fighting until you made eye contact with someone else.

An hour and a half into the event, and the fight was as energetic as when it started. Pillow Fight Toronto seemed to have a therapeutic effect. No matter how people felt as they walked into the fight, everyone left feeling as soft and fluffy as the pillows they brought.

All in all, Pillow Fight Toronto was an awesome time to hang out with friends, meet up with old ones, and make new ones... and a once-a-year opportunity to deal with unresolved anger in a fun, loving way.

Where else can you beat up random strangers in the heart of Toronto?

I'd definitely recommend going next year. 10/10



by FRIEDA RONG

Footprints

by MOUJAN SADERI

My life is just the same as yours, I have five fingers on each hand, But faint footprints in dark gray, Everywhere they land.

I walk, and run, and dance, like you, But faint footprints in dark gray, will appear where they'll remain forever, as I walk away.

The paths I take, these marks I make, They are my legacy, The earth is left forever scarred, By the memory of me.

I try to lead a normal life, But my footprints boldly say, That I walk along the same roads, As I did yesterday.

Footprints cover my bedroom floor, And outline my route to school, They scream that I am a caged bird, They insist that I am a fool.

A fool who refuses to step off the trail, Who is too frightened to explore, Mindlessly retracing steps he has taken, A million times before.

The footprints haunt my every step, They fill me with dread and with woe, But I have yet to reach a dead end, so onwards I must go.

A Foreigner's Guide to Travels in Paris

by LAUREN CHANG and DAVID CHEN-LI

Curious about going to Paris but unsure of what to expect? Here are some highlights brought to you by The Reckoner!

1. The Eiffel tower is a spectacular place to visit. Try to visit during the night time, as smog and pollution obscures your view of Paris from the top during the day. The tower itself can be viewed from many areas in the city, and it will be up to you to decide which scene you enjoy the most.

2. Carousels in Paris are common, and somehow much more magical than the sad one we have at Wonderland. Other than being extremely ornate and decorative, they are also two floors high. However, do not get onto merry-go-rounds even if they're not fenced, especially if they begin to move. Remember, you most definitely need a billet, and the man who owns the carousel will chase you down.

3. Art museums are amazing, especially if you know anything about Impressionism. You are going to see amazing arts

in small places. The Louvre is the most famous, but it is also the most tourist-heavy and the loudest. The smaller ones are breathtaking, and Madame knows her stuff. You'll see one made from an old train station housing Van Gogh, a beautiful garden littered with Rodin's statues and one where the walls are filled with the glow of Monet's Water Lilies. Even if art isn't really your thing, seeing all this history in real life is the heart of this trip.

Did you know that Garneau's French department runs a trip to Paris? For more information contact Madame Matthews. For people who have already decided on going, you can sign up at www.explorica.ca/Matthews-135



Picture: David Chen-Li

MY OWN CHRISTIAN GREY FLAVOURED DISASTER

by LAUREN CHANG

Fifty Shades of Grey has quickly become a cultural phenomenon, and has driven many to take sides. Some are enamored with the so-called 'mommy porn', while others are critical of the significance of its popularity, and what it teaches us about our society. Others are wary of the book's graphic sexual content, while some trash the writing style.

All are legitimate opinions, of course, but I decided to read the book before taking other people's opinions on the subject.

FSofG (Fifty Shades of Grey) began as a Twilight fanfiction aptly named, 'Master of the Universe' by 'Snowqueen's Icedragon', which was posted on fanfiction websites before being taken down, and reposted on 'FiftyShades.com' after concerns about its sexual nature. Later on, E.L.James changed the names of the characters, and published it under the name 'Fifty Shades of Grey'. In 2012, FSofG had outsold the entire Harry Potter series on Amazon, and was #1 for 20 weeks on USA Today's best selling books. The book was turned into a movie, the characters of Christian Grey and Anastasia Steele played by Jamie Doman and Dakota Johnson, respectively. It was released on February 13th, and made \$81.7 million in sales on the 3 day weekend.

The plot itself follows an insecure English major, Anastasia Steele (referred to as Ana for the majority of the novel), who steps in for her best friend to interview Christian Grey, the young, wealthy and beautiful CEO of Grey Enterprises Holdings Inc. At first sight, Christian is intrigued by the clumsy, unsure-of-herself Ana, and he exhibits stalker-like tendencies through the beginning of the novel; turning up to her workplace and tracking her phone. Eventually Ana learns about Christian's sexual tastes, BDSM, and is introduced to sex by Mr. Grey.

The writing features a lot of increasingly repetitive interjections (like "Holy Cow" or "Oh Gosh"), some oddly placed complicated words (especially in conversation), overuse of adjectives (used generally to describe the sexiness of Christian Grey), and very literal narration. I thought it would be hard to plod through the plot, but it was far more difficult to take the book seriously. The characters were worse. Anastasia Steele is a shy introvert, who seems to be innocent of everything at 21 years. (She did not know how to use a computer, in 2012.) Among other things, she loves to read romantic classics, she seems to be aware of what she lacks, and she's naive. Christian Grey, the tortured 'bajillionaire', is presented as a stuck up pretty-boy, who seems to be good at everything (rich, intelligent, plays piano, knows his wines, can fly a glider, need I go on). Christian Grey was abused as a child, and this seems to be the main reason for all his actions. His BDSM tastes are alright because he is a broken person, and he needs to be understood and fixed. His controlling, abusive and manipulative behaviour is excused by his past.

Many have called the book anti-feminist. At one point, Grey tells Ana that in BDSM, the submissive is really the one in control. Of course, this is while he is emotional-

ly manipulating and trying to control her, which she may or may not be comfortable with. Taking this book at face value, without evaluating the morals, can lead us to believe that what Grey is talking about is true, but his resulting actions speak against what he preaches. At one point Anna says no to sex, but is forced into it; the lack of consent has some people calling it rape. The main idea of BDSM is consent, and the book warps the practice into something it is not. The book has gotten BDSM public attention, but presents it in such a way that it seems that one must have emotional problems, like Grey's history of sexual abuse, in order to participate in any type of kink or fetish.

This sort of behavior affects the reading experience a lot. It's almost easy to agree with the actions of the characters, and fall into the lull of things. It makes the popularity of the book understandable, but brings up some bigger questions. As a society, is it okay for us to make a book that exploits women so popular and so acceptable? Is it enough to dismiss it as 'mommy porn' without acknowledging the cultural significance and resulting assumptions about our culture?

This book has affected real people, and caused tragedy. There are already stories of people assuming this is what women want, and raping - even killing them in the name of FSofG's BDSM. People are mistaking BDSM with violence and sex, and that non-consent can be ignored as inhibition. Under violence and pain, 'no' is normal, but in a sexual way, 'no' is just an involuntary reaction, and leads to pleasure. A Swedish man beat his girlfriend 123 times with a blackboard pointer before she asphyxiated due to something being shoved in her mouth. He said that she was a willing 'sex slave', but her journal stated that she was subservient, not a masochist. Another man was trying to recreate a FSofG scene, by whipping, punching and raping a college girl, even after she cried and begged him to stop.

This book has brought up so many issues that the positives may be hard to find. It shoves women into the submissive role, and men into the dominant role, supporting gender stereotypes under the guise of freedom of sexuality. It normalizes unhealthy behaviour, without realizing that the possessiveness and cruelty of its main character is not a sign of his love or in any way excusable.

The whirlwind that has been Fifty Shades of Grey can not be completely dismissed as a stain on literature and popular culture, because it has brought up problems in our society that need to be addressed. Consume the media with a grain of salt, and don't take others opinions at first glance. Fifty Shades of Grey is easy to overlook because of its sexual content and bad prose, but its impact is more important than the novel itself.

To conclude this review, although the book was certainly enlightening, I do think I will be returning to this series. I'm afraid Mr. Grey will not see me now.

“Art”

by JESSICA FUNG



ASK THE RECKONER

All of my friends are getting into amazing universities, american and the like, while I'm getting rejection after rejection. I know I should just be happy for them, but all I can feel is jealousy and self loathing. I feel like crying even as I'm writing this. What's wrong with me? How do I stop this? Help. -FeelingDepressed

Hey there, Though you may not notice it, these feelings that you are getting are also experienced by everyone else, all the time. For example, I'm sure many students feel jealous of another student's perfect score on a test, and then lose self-confidence because of it. There is nothing wrong with that, and there is nothing wrong with you! Being jealous of your friend's achievements is only natural, and the important part is how you choose to deal with it.

In the end, you will have to accept that each person has their strengths and weaknesses, and everyone will have their own opportunity to shine. Be happy for the achievements of others, and they will be there to congratulate you as well in the future. Admitting your jealousy is already a big step towards making peace with yourself, and is a reaction that is much better than hate or anger. Take some time to think about your own strengths, and remember that you don't have to compare yourself to others. There will always be people that are better than you in one way or another, so instead you should compare yourself to how you were in the past. If you're improving, that's all that matters.

Finally, remember that jealousy isn't always a bad thing. It creates some healthy competition that will motivate you to work harder and become the better person you wish to be. No matter which university you end up at, if you work hard and believe in yourself you will be able to achieve your own goals. Cheer up, your moment of glory will come eventually.

I think I'm a great detective. I also think that someone in my class is bribing teachers and administrators for high marks. Even though he's such a god, I still feel that he's cheating somehow (totally not out of my personal insecurities). How do I expose these vile and low-life actions of this scum?

-A great detective-basically sherlock holmes

I've always gotten away before with bribing teachers and administrators, but I think people are catching onto me. Recently, I received perfects on all my courses, and my classmates all praised me for it. But this one guy who thinks he's a great detective is suspecting me. How can I continue to get away with bribing my teachers?

-RollingInTheDough

If you seek counsel from The Reckoner like the individuals above, send us a question at www.thereckoner.ca/ask-the-reckoner

TDSB Supplies

TDSB Supplies Continued from P1

by DAVID CHEN-LI

Within a secondary school, teachers can utilize the allocated budget in order to allow them to practical- for their department to order materials and classroom supplies. The process, however, is specifically structured by the Board. The TDSB

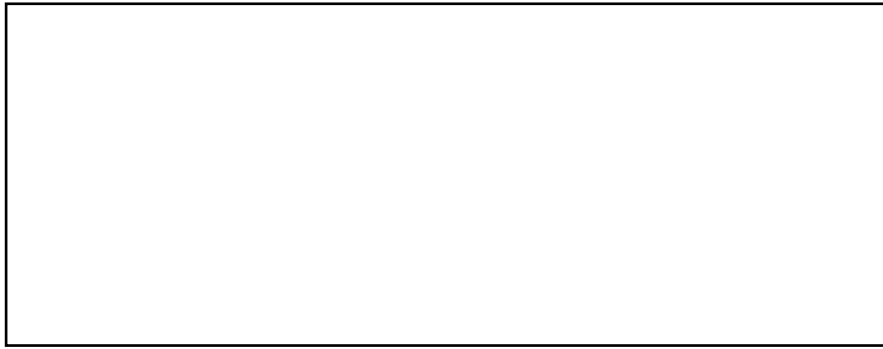


Illustration by Joy Wang

has a central distribution centre for supplies and materials which schools order from. This distribution centre is divided into four silos which help narrow down where teachers put their orders. Teachers need only to apply for a supply order from their curriculum department head, and the department head then files an order to the distribution centre for the supplies. The TDSB buys the stock in the distribution centre in bulk from stores that apply to be a TDSB vendor. This is in order to save money for the Board in the long run, which is understandable for common items that are purchased in bulk, such as construction paper or pencils. If teachers require something more specific, and is not listed in the TDSB catalogue, they can purchase the item from a TDSB approved vendor and apply for a reimbursement.

However, these policies create a limitation for elective subject teachers; certain subject teachers may require specific, and often obscure items for their course and what they plan to teach. If teachers cannot find their item in the TDSB catalogue or from approved vendors, then they must pay for it out of their own pocket. This restricts the amount of flexibility that teachers have with the content that they teach in the course. For example, if robotics teachers want to provide their students with

robotic equipment of a specific kind in order to allow them to practical- ly apply their knowledge, then they would be forced to find an alternative to their original idea or pay for it all and receive no reimbursement

from the Board. Teachers are not obligated to use their own money for their students, and so they may ditch the idea altogether. The policy that the Board puts in place for classroom supplies fails to achieve its money saving objective as well. Considering that prices are fixed throughout the year, and teachers only get reimbursed from specific vendors if they do not purchase through the TDSB catalogue, the policy denies teachers the opportunity to utilize their own sources to purchase more frugally for the classroom. Teachers should be allowed to submit a form or an application for review, detailing what materials they wish to purchase, where they plan to purchase it, and for how much money. They should also be made appropriately aware of the amount of money available to them. The TDSB then approves or denies the request, allowing teachers the freedom to purchase supplies where they choose. A restricted list of TDSB approved vendors is then unnecessary, as the Board will review teachers' decisions before allowing them to purchase.

While the TDSB supplies policies may have seemed ideal in the past, the evolution of elective studies requires a broader, more encompassing system for the Board to support students. ■

FIFA Elections

FIFA

Continued from P1

Indeed, corruption seems to be a common theme throughout Blatter's career. Blatter's own former deputy and protege, Michel Zen-Ruffinen, wrote a 30-page document alleging that the collapse of one of FIFA's partners, ISL, had cost FIFA over \$100 million. The collapse was supposedly caused by ISL paying huge sums to FIFA officials in exchange for television contracts. In April 2012, the Council of Europe implicated Blatter in this scandal, saying that it would be "difficult to imagine" that Blatter had not been aware of ISL's payments and subsequent bankruptcy.

Even when corruption and financial incompetence is not the main issue, Blatter has still made a variety of controversial statements. On racism in soccer: "There is no racism." On soccer star John Terry's alleged extramarital affair: "If this had happened in let's say Latin countries then I think he would have been applauded." On women's soccer: "Wear tighter shorts and low cut shirts." On Qatar's anti-gay policies: "I would say they (gay fans) should refrain from any sexual activities." The list goes on.

It is clear that Blatter's reign has turned FIFA, and himself, into a laughingstock. Among Figo's proposals include expanding the World Cup to include 40 or even 48 countries, reverting to the old offside rule, and implementing "sin bins" (similar to hockey's penalty boxes). However, each of these proposals are problematic. A 40 or 48 country tournament, with games every 3 days, in a country as warm as Qatar would be very taxing for players. In fact, on Figo's part, including more countries in the World Cup seems like a blatant effort to win votes from smaller nations. Sin bins and offside rules could also significantly slow the pace of the game and are largely seen as unnecessary.



Illustration: Name Name

On the contrary, both van Praag and Al-Hussein are seasoned soccer officials who have impressive, and more importantly, clean track records. However, the fact that both candidates are in the running is likely to split the anti-Blatter vote. Furthermore, it looks as if most of the national soccer organizations are already in Blatter's pocket - neither van Praag nor Al-Hussein seem to have enough clout to turn the race in their favour. In conclusion, while most independent observers can agree that Blatter needs to go, it seems like that will never happen. ■

A Fool's Mentality

OP-ED by DAVID HAO

Were you tricked this April Fools' Day? Every year on 1 April, eye-brows are raised and suspicious heights, as we take that extra moment of consideration when evaluating what we hear and see. Friends become untrustworthy, news sources become questionable, and the internet becomes a minefield of intentional deception as we're left to fend for ourselves with only our judgment to guide us. This particular cynicism is well-founded, stemming from a nearly 500 year old history of practical jokes and hoaxes. April Fools' Day represents the one day of the year where we tread lightly and consider mindfully before we accept what is presented in front of us.

But what about the rest of the year? For the vast majority of us, media outlets and the internet represent our primary sources of news and factual information. They've become familiar to us - we've learned to trust these sources and accept information without much thought towards its credibility. Take a moment to consider the last time you doubted a story on the 6:00 PM news. It's not surprising that we have adapted to blindly consuming information, as long as we place trust in the source.

However, this mentality is fundamentally flawed. As consumers of information, we stand as the watchdogs that hold the source institutions accountable for the integrity of their content. The foundational principles of journalism are to report the truth and serve the people. In an ideal world, our media outlets would operate by these principles, but it is important to remember that news agencies are businesses, operating on financial and even political agendas. When we allow ourselves to submit to these institutions without considering the validity of their content, we are enabling the media to get away with reporting fallacies or hyperbolic information.

This is especially true in today's world, where stiff competition exists between news and media sources to get stories out to the public as fast as possible. News is produced at such an incredible speed that compromises can often be made in fact checking or in providing a complete story, which can lead readers to draw false or extrapolative conclusions. Combine this with the current blind acceptance mentality, and it becomes very apparent how easily false information can be propagated.

Most people might consider themselves sensible enough to identify falsehoods when they arise. Here are a few examples to

illustrate just how deeply acceptance at face value and gullibility are rooted in society. On 1 April, 1957, BBC aired a segment featuring "spaghetti trees", showing housewives harvesting spaghetti from these plants, during a time period when spaghetti was still relatively foreign to most of the British population. Hundreds called or wrote in asking for tips on growing their own plant, convinced by words of the world's oldest national broadcasting organisation. Many people automatically associated presented news with factual information. Such was also the case in 1938, when a radio adaptation of Orson Welles's The War of the Worlds broadcasted in news bulletin format caused mass hysteria, as many listeners took the narrative alien invasion as factual.

Less ridiculous to the modern eye, in 2014 internet tricksters managed to convince thousands that their iPhones could be charged by microwaving them, through the online circulation of authentic-looking posters. Similarly, iPhone users were led to believe that a new software update made their phones waterproof. After outrage poured out to the internet in the aftermath, "victims" were left with nobody to blame but themselves. No, these particular hoaxes were not launched on April Fools' Day. If they were, perhaps people would have reconsidered. But if all it takes is a particular date on the calendar to separate healthy skepticism from credulity, then perhaps we as a society are more vulnerable than we think.

So far, the aforementioned examples have all been rather trivial. However, the lack of a critical outlook on presented information can have serious consequences. Following the 2013 Boston Marathon Bombings, internet users launched a massive "crowd-sourced" investigation over social media, falsely identifying 22-year old Sunil Tripathi as the standout suspect through images and video "evidence". Despite there being no concrete evidence linking Tripathi to the attack, the story was quickly picked up by some news agencies and broadcasted or published as a potential lead. Another damaging incident occurred in 2013, when hackers managed to breach the Associated Press' Twitter account, tweeting that explosions had occurred at the White House and that the president was hurt. In the few minutes that the tweet was up for, the Wall Street stock market dived by 150 points, before recovering. It is alarming to see how fast fallacies can spread in the absence of rational consideration.

It is incredibly ironic that April Fools' Day is the one day of the year when people consciously decide to critically evaluate news reports and information. As the audience, we should instead maintain this healthy skepticism in our everyday lives. The propagation of misinformation is harmful, and blurs the lines between truth, falsehoods and opinion at alarmingly rapid rates. So the next time you pick up a newspaper, take a moment to consider if the information is more than what meets the eye. Maybe this editorial is lying to you too. ■

Illustration: Lila Huang



Teacher Feature: Mr. van Bemm

van Bemm
Continued from P1



Mr. van Bemm. Photo: Somebody

And the other thing is, the physical business, the meat business, in many ways is a young man’s job. When you start getting a little older, it’s a little bit harder to get up in the morning after and knowing that’s what you have ahead of you in order to put food on the table. And so I was at a crossroads. I was fortunate enough to not have any dependence at the time, and so I was able to pretty much make my own decisions and I was very lucky to have held that privilege. At one hand I kinda thought it was too late, I was 31, and

my mom was like, well, see if you can get in. And sure my mom was pleased, she would much rather me work in a more professional environment than work for a living so to speak. So I was fortunate enough to get in and fortunate enough to do well enough to end up here.
Q: If you could go back in time and have a conversation with any one person, who would it be and why?
A: Hard to say, you know, you know people by their reputations. Most people would choose some, you know, wise person or whatever. On the other hand it might be nice to meet an ancestor that you never really got to know, hear their stories intermediary to your family. I don’t know because I think when you meet people personally if you don’t have a lot in common, you’re really enraptured by an image, whether it’s a sports hero or a historical hero and I think sometimes the folks who are everyday.. it’d be interesting to meet some people who did make some changes and see what they’re really like and all the rest of it.
Q: How many identical white shirts do you own?
A: 7.
Q: ?? Is that one for each day of the week or..
A: And then 2 for redundancy.
Q: Has your pocket protector ever gone missing or do you have 7 of those

too?
A: No you buy them in lots of 5, and I’ll remind you of pocket protectors. com, you buy them in groups. [Pulls out pocket protector] This one’s already showing the wear and so I will probably replace it pretty soon, with an identical one of course. This is used because shirts are expensive and all you need is one ink stain on your pocket and your shirt’s garbage. So it’s essential, not to be a nerd, generally speaking.
Q: What do you think is the single biggest mistake that students at Garneau make?
A: This is a great school there’s a lot of wonderful people here who teach here and care about the kids, believe me. All I can say to students is you come everyday prepared to really learn whatever you’re willing to learn at whatever level you’re at. It’s got nothing to do with smart you are, it’s gotta do with how you make up your life. There’s a lot of people who’ve had trouble in school and they went out and made a million bucks. If your main job is to goof around, well it’s going to catch up to you some day.
Q: You have a really fantastic assortment of ties. Where do you get them?
A: Well that’s really quite interesting, I probably started with about 15, and on a couple of occasions we encountered a store where the prices were

reasonable and they had some excellent themed ties and we bought those, but I’ve gotten quite a number from students over the years too. And so a couple of years ago my wife gave me a tie holder that has a motor on it, so there’s about 80 of them now, and I’m running out of space, so to be clear I don’t need any more ties. I make sure I wear them in sequence, so they don’t get worn out, so most ties only appear twice a year. I wear a few themed ties on certain days for certain purposes, so beyond that – I even have an Uncle Henry tie, a student got me that too.
Q: Have you ever watched Breaking Bad?
A: No.
Q: It’s about a high school science teacher, much alike yourself in both stature and appearance, who decides to pursue a criminal career producing methamphetamine in order to make ends meet.
A: Well, I have no interest in that. I think the main thing here is that I don’t want to do anything ever to allow my students to feel disappointed in me. I try to go about my day in a way such that I ask a lot of them and I ask a lot of myself and I hope I don’t ever make a mistake that would cause them to be disappointed in me.

Asking Mr. Alexander

ALEXANDER
Continued from P1

At the end of the experience, whether it’s 30 minutes or whatever time there is over the semester, they come out of it changed for the better.
And they leave me behind and move on in their lives to tackle the next set of 4 or 5 30-35 strong groups. They leave me behind but I’m better for that experience.
Q: Do you ever try to inspire your students through your teaching? If so, how do you do it?
A: The answer is yes. If it’s not worth inspiring through, or inspiring by, I don’t know why I should be teaching it. Everything that I do in class, including my silences, has some motivation behind it that I hope has a role to playing the larger inspirational experience. And how do I do it right? I wasn’t very good at this when I first started. I hadn’t experienced it through my teachers either. That’s not a negative comment about them, it’s just the system at the time wasn’t as astute as it is now. There’s an intellectual element, there’s a social element, there’s an emotional element, and there’s usually a philosophical element as well to everything. If you could bring all four of them together, not necessarily all the time, but if they’re generally in alignment, I think things make sense. If as a teacher, I can find ways to make this complicated world sensible to my students, I think they get inspired. Then the world becomes manageable, the subject becomes manageable. Relationships become manageable. It also makes sense for them to trust the ones that have gone before them. My role as a teacher is not necessarily to have them look backwards, but if I can get their heads to look in all directions, they learn from the past, they experience the present, and then they prepare themselves and shape the future.

Q: What’s one aspect of your personal life that you’re willing to share, that students probably wouldn’t expect?
A: I’m pretty open about my classes. I think everything my students need to know, they know through my lessons. They also know how I’ve learned through other people’s lives. One thing people probably don’t know about me is that I write. I don’t think that part will surprise them, that as an English teacher, I want to write. Six or seven years ago, I went away on an earned paid leave to teach in Dubai for a year. I was able to use my time well. I ended up visiting 100 cities in 35 countries in the 14 months I was gone. I wasn’t doing very adventurous things, but because I’m interested in photography, I would go to photograph.
Q: What’s the nicest thing someone’s ever done for you?
A: I’m not going to be able to think of anything specific, but I think generally, whenever someone’s thoughtful and mindful, I find it very nice. I don’t have to agree with whatever it is they’re being mindful about, but just the idea that someone has thought something through and found the time or the energy to make something happen for somebody else is very nice. I also find it very Canadian. It’s part of who we are. We’re just so comfortable with who we are that we allow other people to be who they are. This is the whole give and let give thing I was talking about earlier. ■

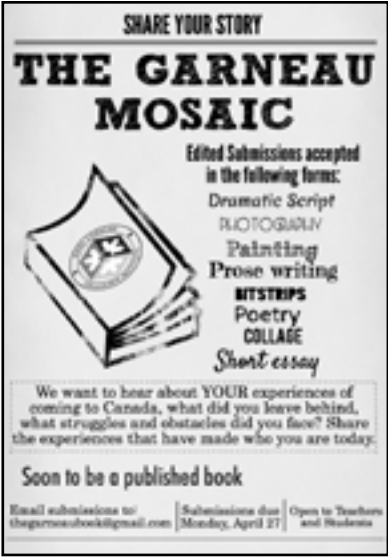
Piecing Garneau Together

by CHENG CHENG LIN

A new project at Marc Garneau C.I. called The Garneau Mosaic is aiming to celebrate cultural diversity within the school. Lead by Jackie Ho and Maria Kashif and with the guidance of Ms. Goldenberg and Ms. Mazzaferro, the Garneau Mosaic committee consists of a small group of students working to complete the project by June 2015.
An anthology of the origins of teachers and students within Marc Garneau, the Mosaic will contain a collection of not only stories, but family photographs, artwork, and even poetry. The project is open to submissions from anyone within the school, and is aiming to capture the multiculturalism of Garneau.
“We want students and teachers to

share their experiences (or their family’s) of coming to Canada and to MGCI, and any other unique stories about their lives,” commented Jackie Ho. Jackie originally wanted the project to expand upon the Reckoner’s Humans of Garneau project, but decided to create a separate cause. Her idea coincided with Ms. Goldenberg’s idea to create and publish a book unique to Garneau experiences, and a student-teacher team was formed. The final creation by the Garneau Mosaic will come in two parts: an in-school display, and a published book with selected stories. The display will be presented for the students of Marc Garneau, and will offer a chance

for stories of origin to be shared. The Garneau Mosaic also received a thousand-dollar Ministry of Education SpeakUp grant after a successful application in October 2014 co-written by Jackie and Maria. Its goal to celebrate diversity and boosting school spirit falls under the SpeakUp theme of embracing diversity and fostering peer-to-peer communities of support. The Garneau Mosaic is now accepting submissions, which can be sent to thegarneaubook@gmail.com. The committee would prefer to receive submissions by Monday 27 April, however it will continue accepting them during the beginning of May. ■



Photos by Khadija Jawwad and Cindy Cui
For more Humans of Garneau, visit www.thereckoner.ca/category/hog/



“What are you most proud of?”

“I guess I’m most proud of the fact that I really care about whatever I pursue. I’m a pianist, but since I don’t take proper piano lessons, I often search up online ways to improve my playing. Sometimes when I can’t find music sheet for a song I want to play, I’ll slow down the music and figure out the notes. When I’m learning a lesson, I try to think about how I can achieve the highest mark I can for it, and if I can’t figure something out, then I’ll search it up online. Sometimes I’ll even read ahead so that I’m more prepared, which is completely unlike how I was before in elementary school. I used to feel discouraged about things, and I’d tell myself, ‘I can never get straight ‘A’s. But when pursuing anything it’s important not to give up, ‘cause there’s really nothing that can stop you from achieving it.

“What are you most passionate about?”

“I’m probably most passionate about social activism. I try to be as informed as I can on social inequalities and ask questions when I have them. Kurt Cobain said it best when he said ‘The duty of youth is to challenge corruption.’ “



The Reckoner

of Marc Garneau C.I.

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